

WILL THE CHAIR HOLD? (From left) Sushumlata Kushwaha, *mukhiya* of Davan panchayat; Rajauli panchayat *mukhiya* Subhadra Devi and husband Vinay Singh

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status in the panchayats.

The Bihar government clearly does not buy this 'first lady' argument. A government order has now made it mandatory for field officers—those in the blocks and district headquarters—to ensure that only the elected women representatives take part in the meetings of the rural local bodies. But it's easier said than done.

Of the 8,400-odd panchayats in Bihar, about half have women *mukhiya*s. And many of them have been propped up by their husbands because the seats are reserved for women. Not only this, the majority of the rural representatives are newly elected after the 11-phase panchayat polls held between September 24 and December 12, 2021. They are just learning the ropes and, for a sizeable number of women *mukhiyas,* tasks like interactions with government officials, checking a bill invoice or assessing project approvals are still unknown territory.

That said, it would be wrong to say that all women *mukhiya*s work as rubber stamps, says Arvind Kumar Choudhary, principal secretary, Bihar panchayati raj department. "These women are well aware of their duties and responsibilities. We are also training the elected representatives on the processes of running a rural self-government," he says.

50%
Bihar was the first state to reserve half its seats in the local bodies for women

Rs 2 crore
Annual allocation a mukhiya gets for development work in a panchayat

₹2,226 crore
Central grant in 2021-22 to Bihar's local bodies for water and sanitation alone

No one is in any doubt about the effect seat reservation has had on advancing the case of women's empowerment in Bihar. An oft-cited example of this is how every state election after the announcement in 2006 has had more female voters than men, an unheard of thing in the past. "Rural Bihar is a changed place now. The patriarchal logic that women must be confined to the kitchen and the household may still be true in pockets, but in many areas they are no longer defined by such medieval mindsets," says Prof. Raghunandan Sharma, former head of the sociology department at Patna University. Clearly, panchayats turning into training grounds for rural women have played a big part in this.

MUKHIYA KINGS...AND QUEENS

A *mukhiya* is often described as the MLA of his or her panchayat. Everything that happens in the rural universe—from the building of schools to the granting of an Indira Awas home or an anganwadi centre to PDS distribution to building of roads—bears the stamp of a *mukhiya*. These rural heads can make things happen, but just as easily create obstacles to delivery. The *mukhiya* also has the advantage of catering to a smaller area, and much smaller population. A panchayat consists of a group of contiguous villages with a population of about 7,000.

If plotted against the 243 assembly seats in Bihar, each constituency on an average would have almost 35 panchayats in it. However, when it comes to fund allocation, a *mukhiya* is much better placed than an MLA. While legislators have an annual allocation of Rs 3 crore as local area development fund—with which he/ she has to attend to the entire constituency—a *mukhiya* has about Rs 2 crore for development work for a much smaller area.

This apart, in accordance with the 15th Finance Commission recommendations, the Centre set aside a cumulative grant of Rs 11,735 crore (starting with Rs 2,226 crore in 2021-22) to the rural local bodies for water and sanitation alone. Besides, the panchayats will now cater to healthcare needs in rural areas as well. This will involve setting up primary health centres (PHCs), additional PHCs and health centres as well as a supply of medicines. Added responsibilities include the authority to vet work and even release payments for contract work.

Funds are flowing into the panchayats, and the 15th Finance Commission is also recommending that they function as 'public utilities with a focus on service delivery'. The *mukhiya*'s role is now set to gain even more significance. One hopes the spouses don't overshadow the women *mukhiya*s. ■